

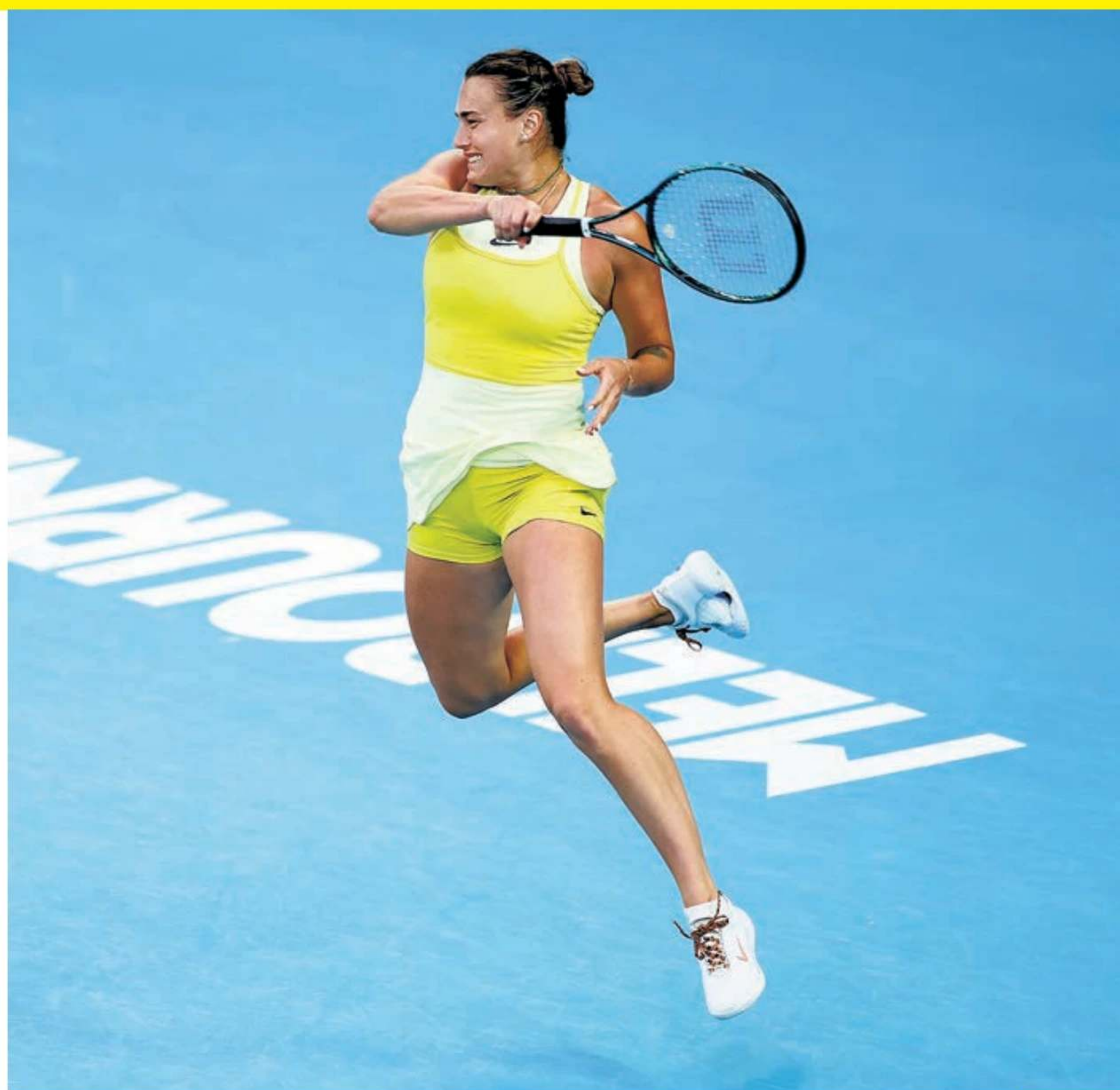
husband last November. A former junior star who beat Dominic Thiem in the 2011 French Open boys' final and later ranked No. 99 on the ATP Tour, Fratangelo advised Keys for several years before becoming her official coach 18 months ago. He put the critical final touches on her technique, tactics, and equipment.

"What I've tried to instil in her is that winning and losing is irrelevant, but how you lose and how you win matters," Fratangelo told *The Athletic*. "Don't lose being passive, because it's not who you are. Let a counterpuncher lose being passive because that's what they do. You lose putting your foot on the gas pedal and that's OK. It's going to happen."

Under his guidance, Maddie — as her friends affectionately call her — changed her serve from a platform stance to a step-up one. That enabled Keys to land farther inside the baseline, putting her in a better position to attack with her booming forehand. Concomitantly, she lowered her service toss to keep her swing continuous, which increased her consistency. Keys switched from a Wilson racket to a lighter Yonex, which she can manoeuvre better, and to harness her power with added topspin, she changed her strings from half polyester and half gut to all poly.

Ironically, Keys found inspiration from Sabalenka. The world No. 1 enjoyed a 4-1 dominance in their rivalry, beating her all three times on hard courts and both times at Slam events. "The one thing I really wanted to try to be better at was not playing more passively in big points and just trying to emulate the way she trusts her game and the way she goes after it," she told *Eurosport*. "If you're able to do that and you miss and you lose, it's on your terms. I think her ability to always go for it, no matter what the score, is really impressive. She plays such fearless tennis. She has the ability to play so well that way. I think it's unique."

And for seven straight matches at a Major, Keys proved she could perform like that too. Even more impressive, the 22-1 pre-tournament longshot beat four top-10 opponents



to equal an Open Era record. Only one victory came easy, though. In the opening rounds, Keys edged fellow American Ann Li 6-4, 7-5, and outlasted Romanian qualifier Elena-Gabriela Ruse 7-6 (1), 2-6, 7-5.

Collins clashes with the crowd

Next came the No. 10 seed, Danielle Collins, who had been friends and pen pals with Keys since they were 10. Collins, the 2022 finalist at Melbourne, became annoyed by hecklers during her 7-6 (4), 4-6, 6-2 win over hometown favourite Destanee Aiava. Afterward, she sarcastically blew several kisses to them, one before touching her derriere — "Kiss my *ss!" in American parlance.

When Collins entered the court to play Keys, the fans booed the fiery American, and yet again when the trainer arrived mid-match to check her knee. Djokovic, who has often battled hecklers during his controversial career, supported Collins. "I loved her response. I loved it. Everything she said on the court,

Not this time: Sabalenka, who was looking to win her third straight AO crown, gave it all in the final. GETTY IMAGES

off the court.... I know exactly the feeling. So, I think she was funny, smart."

To the delight of the crowd, the popular Keys thumped Collins 6-4, 6-4. Afterward, *Tennis Channel* analyst Prakash Amritraj said, "I don't care who you are. That has to be tough to deal with."

In the fourth round, Keys encountered the placid but heavy-hitting sixth seed, Elena Rybakina, the 2022 Wimbledon champion and 2023 Australian Open runner-up to Sabalenka. The 6' Kazakh, under new coach Goran Ivanisevic, looked uninspired and slow as Keys prevailed 6-3, 1-6, 6-3.

Keys volleyed superbly, winning 23 of 26 net points to overcome 28th seed Elina Svitolina in a 3-6, 6-3, 6-4 quarterfinal test. Her improved serve technique paid off as her first serve